

8 “Before man reaches the moon, your mail will be delivered within hours from New York to Australia by guided missiles. We stand on the threshold of rocket mail.”

— Arthur Summerfield, U.S. Postmaster General, 1959

Well, SpaceX is only just figuring out how to reverse land rockets, so I don't know—maybe we'll have rocket mail after all. When I first came across this statement made by the then U.S. Postmaster General, I thought he was just indulging in some good old wishful thinking. Then I found a Wikipedia page on “rocket mail” and found out that for a while, they were actually testing rockets to deliver



mail, and at one point, even the US Navy got involved. Upon further thought, one could argue the case for rocket mail: It's possibly the fastest physical way to deliver mail. There's just one minor concern, rockets do this thing where they can sometimes

lose their trajectory and end up levelling an entire city block, at which point you have to stop and ask yourself: “How important is the expedited delivery of mail really?” The idea was finally dropped when they realized that the cost of rocket fuel and the expense of running the operation would never justify the incremental gain in the speed of mail delivered—something even a slightly clued in high school science student would tell you long before you go testing those rockets. The silver lining in this cloud is that eventually Rocketmail did happen, and it was instant, and it was delivered over the Internet, and as far as I can tell, no one's life was put at risk.

9 “The subscription model of buying music is bankrupt.”

— Steve Jobs, 2003

Not too visionary, Steve, not too visionary at all. In 2014, an estimated 41 million people paid for music subscription services, the number having gone up from 8 million in just four years. Last year, the total annual revenue from streaming music hit a record \$2.4bn. And streaming music is now the largest contributor of revenue to the music industry at 34.3%, ahead of both downloads (34%) and physical (28.8%). Apple launched its own subscription service called Apple Music last year, which has already acquired one-third the number of subscribers that the market leader Spotify has. In fact, the buzz is that the subscription model is working out so well for Apple that it may soon be discontinuing iTunes digital downloads entirely in favor of the Apple Music subscription model. I guess Apple couldn't afford to miss the gravy train, even though their supreme deity had publicly spoken it over a decade ago. Must be hard.



10 “Two years from now, spam will be solved.”

— Bill Gates at the World Economic Forum, 2004

Hey Bill, I know you're smart and everything, but please tell that to the Nigerian prince who just emailed me this morning requesting



my bank details because he just inherited a few hundred million dollars that he needs to redistribute in multiple accounts across the world to hide it from his own predatory government. I shouldn't be mocking, I must be getting my share of \$7 million any minute now. The mandatory Nigerian

prince spam joke aside, spam is still pretty much alive and kicking, although intelligent spam filters try to keep us protected from it. Kaspersky Labs recently estimated that almost as much as 70% of all email is spam. The reason why spam is so pervasive and often difficult to track is because a majority of spam is not sent by the spammer, but by infecting and hijacking the computers of other people like you and I using malware.

11 “Within the next two decades, autos will be made with folding wings.”

— Eddie Rickenbacker, pilot, 1924

Just coincidentally, this is the exact same thing I told my dad two decades ago when I was a kid, so I totally get you, Eddie, and I know exactly where you're coming from. Unfortunately, the world is yet to deliver on our dreams.

At that time, Eddie probably had no idea that the world had a probably the most devastating war, in store.

All of the research then went into making bombs, and even car manufacturers joined the war effort, and made guns and tanks, instead of luxury cars, and nobody really spent any time into thinking up a flying car.

Even today, we have cars faster than the speed of sound, amphibious cars, but we still don't have a car with wings. One would think that manufacturers would concentrate all research on flying cars, and completely ignore measly issues like global warming, and the possibility of species-wide extinction.

A few small form factor, light-capable machines do exist now, the Akoya amphibious aircraft for instance, which can land on ground, water, and snow without adaptation, has a length of 6.9m, wingspan of just 11m, cruising speed of 210 km/h, and a range of 1250 kms—pretty damn cool!—but it's still more a plane with wheels than a car with wings.

Can someone please explain to me why we're building hyper-loops and particle colliders and exploring Mars when we can't even give the masses the simple luxury of a flying car? It's 2016 already! Come on!

